

6

Platforms and Strategic Political Communication

Chapter 6 introduces readers to strategic communication, which includes a wide array of things, including political marketing, advertising, public relations, lobbying, and public diplomacy. We discuss the history of these practices in Western democracies along with their theoretical and ethical underpinnings, and detail how platforms have changed strategic communication. In this chapter, we cover everything strategic that is not directly related to elections and movements. While election campaigns and movements are strategic communication, too, they each get their own chapter ([Chapters 7](#) and [8](#), respectively).

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- give an overview of strategic political communication in the platform era
- have deep knowledge about strategic communication and changes in public opinion
- understand political marketing
- provide an assessment of public relations and public diplomacy
- explain concepts such as crisis communication
- discuss digital lobbying.

6.1 Introduction

Strategic political communication is as old as humanity itself. People have always sought to craft stories, make appeals, persuade and mobilize others, and otherwise forge forms of collectivity and solidarity to create and pursue some shared ends. *Any* attempt to legitimize a ruler or party or political system, persuade citizens about a political issue, convince advocacy organizations about a policy, or contest the meanings or understandings of actions or statements that concern public matters – or matters someone wants to make public – is strategic political communication.

By “strategic,” we mean that there has to be intent behind the communication, whether it is to legitimate, persuade, convince, contest, or secure power in line with some pre-established political, social, or communicative goal. The idea of “strategy” requires whoever is doing the communicating – whether it is governments, campaigns, political leaders, non-governmental organizations, or citizens – to have something they want to achieve. This is different from processes like “deliberation,” where the goal is to arrive at a

shared set of ends in a mutual, or general, interest. Strategic communication might seek to convince people of shared ends and general interests, or it might be in the service of self-interest, personal ends, or achieving power over others. Strategic communication deserves its own chapter in this book because it goes *far* beyond election campaigns, which we focus on in [Chapter 7](#).

This chapter concerns the broad spectrum of political actors – such as parties, regulatory agencies, social movements, elected leaders, and governments – who define goals and develop and pursue communicative strategies and tactics to achieve them. Advocacy groups, lobbyists, citizens, activists, local administrations, and even guerilla groups engage in strategic political communication. They vary in what they want to achieve, the means they employ to achieve their goals, how public their communication is, and even what they can legitimately do communicatively. Not all strategic communication takes place in the public eye, and communicators do not always seek to leverage the attention of the mainstream public to achieve their goals. Lobbyists, for instance, will often avoid public attention, especially if what they promote is unpopular or ill reputed. Lobbyists working for the tobacco or arms industries, for instance, often prefer direct connections with politicians rather than public campaigns in order to influence policymaking or avoid state regulation. Political groups may use public attention to build political pressure on decision-makers, presenting their goals as pressing issues for the common good (e.g. climate activists) or calling for immediate action around specific events that violate moral orders (e.g. protesters against police violence). Other groups might make more narrow appeals to identity groups to pursue or secure power (e.g. religious factions).

In other words, the nature of the goals and the type of actor shape what, how, when, and why actors engage in strategic communications – as do the broader sets of cultural meanings that provide structure and order to societies (see Adams & Kreiss 2021). In the twenty-first century in countries around the world, strategic political communication can take many, many forms. That said, strategic communication of many different stripes often takes shape through media. Indeed, the construction of monuments and the architecture of governmental buildings are media and forms of strategic political communication constructed to legitimate rule and enhance the power of office (J. D. Peters 2016; Sonnevend 2016). However, in this chapter, we focus on the changing nature of strategic communication in an era of digital media and technology platforms. This includes the ways in which public relations, political marketing, political advertising, and public diplomacy are taking on new casts as struggles to influence public opinion and journalism and even political debate are now increasingly conducted online.

6.2 Strategic Communication and Public Opinion in the Platform Era

Strategic communication is ultimately about persuasion. In the absence of coercion by force – and in lieu of other forms of political authority (such as religious authority) – democracies are generally premised on non-coercive forms of political consent. Securing political consent happens through contests to represent the public in a variety of elected offices; the need for legislators and regulators to (at least appear to) be responsive to public opinion; the expectation that government offices, the courts, and public officials have a degree of transparency and accountability for actions; and the hope that those governing will be responsive to public demands. And, in the platform era, this includes many new

demands from the public for transparency from and accountability over a wide range of political, social, and commercial actors. Ultimately, these are ideals. In reality, in many democratic countries, elections are shaped by money and partisanship, leaders and legislatures are imperfectly sensitive to public policy preferences, and offices are unevenly transparent and accountable (e.g. Hacker & Pierson 2020). Different countries have taken varying approaches to dealing with these issues, including through creating agonistic (i.e. adversarial) monitory systems made up of many different actors (Keane 2018), but all democracies share a common orientation toward the need for much of everyday governance to be premised on consent, not force.

As such, strategic communication is central to democracy. In the course of governance, political actors need to *justify* their actions to the public, explain why they took the actions that they did, and defend them – and increasingly that means taking to social media. In democratic contests, such as elections, rivals have to make a case for why they are best positioned to represent the public and protect civic life, and why their opponent is not (Dayan & Katz 1992). And when political actors are accused of doing something wrong, or making a mistake, they have to defend themselves from institutions and actors seeking to hold them accountable (Alexander 2011). All of this is premised on strategic communication – the attempt to shape audiences’ perceptions of public events and issues (Couldry et al. 2009; Scannell 1995).

The central battleground for strategic communication is public opinion, which is increasingly shaped, represented, and fought over on digital and social media platforms. At the heart of strategic communication, and professional practices such as public relations, is often a foundational concern with public opinion – representing it, strategically invoking it, or changing it (Strömbäck & Kiousis 2019). Public opinion can be a complicated and confusing concept (see our extended discussion in [Chapter 4](#)), but broadly we use it here to mean the representation of the attitudes or beliefs of some group of non-elite people.

A quick recap. Public opinion is about “the pictures in our heads,” as Walter Lippman put it in his path-breaking book in 1922. Public opinion carries the internal paradox of being about both the individual opinions of citizens and their averaging to be a “public.” Public opinion can be produced and represented for many ends: to predict election results, craft policies that are responsive to people’s needs, estimate the (un)popularity of politicians and political decisions, reveal how citizens perceive other countries and their country’s relations with them – in addition to many other things. The quality of these measurements depends on the empirical methods and how well they are applied. For instance, is a survey or an opinion poll representative of the population whose attitudes it seeks to measure? Does it create valid results – meaning can the questions asked actually indicate what they seek to measure?

Let us take a look at a few things. First, generally “public opinion” does not apply to institutions or elites. For that, we use phrases such as “elite opinion” (also the object of strategic communication – see Tedesco 2019) or focus specifically on what elites and institutions state or generally believe. At the same time, we are concerned with the *representation* of public opinion. As we argued above, *all* public opinion is represented in some way (e.g. Law 2009). Think of a survey about public attitudes toward climate change. The questions that researchers ask are what creates public opinion; the public’s attitudes and beliefs did not manifest themselves independently from the survey. Even if some public got together and wrote a collective statement among its members, it would still be a representation of what that public believes because it selectively involves choices. In

practice, many, many political actors create representations of public opinion (e.g. Herbst 1998) – journalists when they write on behalf of the public, lobbyists when they urge policymakers to pass a piece of legislation, political candidates when they make claims as to what publics want, and social movements when they chant “The people united will never be defeated.”

To take this point further, because it is central to understanding strategic communication: public opinion is indelibly linked to the ways we have of representing it. Think, for instance, about how we know about what publics think, what their opinions are. Publics cannot tell us these things on their own. Opinions have to be represented in various ways. Historically, polling and surveys have been important ways of representing public opinion – those ranges of attention to issues, attitudes, beliefs, values, and priorities that some statistically represented publics hold (Igo 2007). There are many, many other ways of understanding public opinion though. Legislators often understand public opinion through the lens of what lobbyists and advocacy and interest groups bring to their attention. Journalists represent public opinion for elites and publics themselves through the production of their stories. Social media, in turn, have become key domains where actors create and represent public opinion (McGregor 2019). Platforms give rise to forms of public opinion through their affordances – the way that they create and organize certain forms of sociality and communication. They also represent public opinion in certain ways, such as through the analytics they provide to political practitioners (Kreiss & McGregor 2019). This is why platforms are central to strategic communication – and a central focus of parties, campaigns, candidates, and political leaders that are vying for power.

Strategic communication is the practice of influencing public opinion, but also of creating publics for strategic ends (Aronczyk 2013; Aronczyk & Powers 2010; Cronin 2018). Much of the work of strategic political communicators involves transforming formerly private individuals or associations into publics, and helping to create and define their interests. To take an example, environmentalists often appeal to consumers to make more sustainable lifestyle choices. When consumers do so, they are acting *politically* as a public in accord with a public issue (i.e. sustainability). Publics can also exist and endure over time – think of the ways in which organized religious groups argue for their values and interests, and advance a set of policy claims, sometimes over decades, as defined publics (Morehouse 2021). Often this persistence is premised on institutions, organizations, and media that support publics, provide them with resources and definition, and give shape to and represent their interests in consistent ways (Aronczyk & Espinoza 2021). Indeed, as we noted earlier, publics are often *made* through communication. This occurs whenever people are persuaded to recognize a shared interest with political implications and to come and work together to define goals and advance their aims, or when people are drawn to causes and engage in them socially and symbolically (Pacher 2018).

Strategic communication, then, is centrally concerned with the making, convening, mobilizing, persuading, maintenance, or manipulation of publics, and is intimately tied to the media systems it takes shape in. As a professional practice pursued by an identifiable and specialized group of people, it dates from the early 1900s in countries such as the United States, the result of growth in administrative and bureaucratic states and population growth, which made communication relating to politics and governance more complicated (Greenberg 2016). This was further facilitated by the growth of mass communication technologies throughout the course of the twentieth century in many Western democracies, and the increasing professionalization and institutionalization of journalism, as well as the

marketing industry (Carlson et al. 2021). These developments meant that communication with publics took place across increasingly differentiated media with their own genres of communication, even as things such as the journalistic “beat system” (routine dimensions and areas of society that journalists cover, such as crime, business, the prime minister) meant reporting that standardized a number of events, occasions, and roles for political communicators.

While the core need to get messages to the public, or otherwise influence it in significant ways, is old, strategic communication took on increasingly specialized and mediated roles throughout the course of the twentieth century. For example, professional commercial advertising in the early twentieth century profoundly influenced the conduct of public affairs (Fowler et al. 2021a). In countries such as the US in the 1950s and 1960s, advertising was increasingly being based on psychological research, and with the widespread use of television a whole new world of potential advertising channels had emerged (Fowler et al. 2021a; Kaid & Johnston 2001). From the 1970s on, political advertisers and direct marketers developed an increasingly sophisticated suite of data-based tools to appeal to publics – such as direct mail, cable television advertising, and later the Internet and platforms (Baldwin-Philippi 2019).

There has long been debate and concern over the effects of these things. Initially, many policymakers, scholars, and experts believed that mass media heavily influenced what people thought. Take the myth about people fleeing in panic after the radio broadcast of Orson Welles’s famous fictional news tale of alien invasion “War of the Worlds” in 1938. Or so the story goes – there is little evidence that anyone had panicked at all (Schwartz 2015). This myth resonated among journalists and publics deeply concerned with Nazi propaganda in the 1930s and 1940s. Many believed (then and now) that advertisements and other forms of strategic political communication are able to get directly into people’s heads and manipulate their behavior – not so different than the “moral panics” about Cambridge Analytica after the Brexit referendum and the 2016 US election (see Jamieson 2020).

At the same time, research always painted a much more complicated picture than people as simple dupes of media messages (Neuman 2014). Research consistently shows how people are embedded in social networks that influence them, for instance, and engage in “motivated reasoning” to continue to believe in things that are already consistent with their identities, values, and beliefs (Vegetti & Mancosu 2020).

6.3 Strategic Communication in the Platform Era

If strategic communication is *old*, the contexts in which it takes place today are not. In fact, strategic communication has grown much more complicated in the past two decades. This is related to both technological and media change, as well as the social and professional practices of strategic communication that take shape on platforms. For much of the twentieth century in countries around the world, for instance, the media that strategic communication was practiced on were truly *mass*. This meant large-scale print publications (such as newspapers and magazines), radio, and television. What made them mass is that they reached large, generally geographically differentiated, publics. Of course, there have always been small-scale media, including petitions, fliers, pamphlets, newsletters, local broadcasters, and local-circulation or trade and industry group newspapers and magazines that created, sustained, or communicated between smaller-scale publics. And there have always been mass-circulation media that speak to ideologically distinct, partisan, and other

identity group audiences, especially in countries with media systems that map onto the composition of groups in society. That said, mass, undifferentiated media became a central, if not dominant, feature of many countries over the course of the twentieth century, and the professional practice of specialized strategic communication reflected that.

With mass media, the construction of audiences was generally routinized (Davis 2002; Maloney & McGrath 2021). Professional journalists regularly produced news stories in standardized and consistent ways. Beat systems meant that, even if journalists did not know what the next day's news would be, they knew where to find it: at centers of government power such as legislatures, courts, executive offices, and police headquarters. Representatives of these agencies, as strategic communicators, subsidize news by providing information to journalists, while also seeking to represent their institutions in a strategically favorable light. Politicians developed press apparatuses – communications directors, press secretaries, etc. – to both communicate with their constituents and portray their actions in favorable ways. Organizations such as trade associations, advocacy organizations, and interest groups developed their own press operations and built regular ties with journalists in order to educate them on policy issues and have media coverage represent their preferred positions favorably.

These mass media systems did not disappear so much as newer media, and especially digital media, got layered onto them. This means media systems are “hybrid” and juxtapose newer and older technologies. This layering means a few things of relevance for strategic communication.

First, it means the increasing speed of information in political life. Many countries have moved from daily, 24-hour news cycles to “always on” news cycles that never really end, given continual, and fast, flows of information (Elmer et al. 2012). Second, it means the proliferation of publics and complex flows of political information. As we have documented throughout this book, while professional journalism remains important for organizing audiences and publics in public affairs, alongside this is the seemingly endless profusion of new groups and audiences sustained through communication, which give shape to social life (Bennett 2021; Entman & Usher 2018). This includes groups on Facebook organized around demographic or affiliational interests, network flows of political information built around social ties, curated flows and groups built around interest and identity, and “affective publics” shaped by emotional flows of communication (Papacharissi 2015).

Third, it has led to a profusion of professional and non-professional communicators. The Internet, and platforms especially, have dramatically lowered the cost and capital required to produce political information and speak to publics. This has had sweeping implications. This shift has allowed entirely new publishers to enter the market for political information – often with unclear journalistic or other editorial standards, hyper-partisan and interest group orientations, or organized around ideology and identity (Tandoc 2019). Meanwhile, it has opened political communication to a vast new array of people who were formerly effectively denied the opportunity to address publics, especially those far from the seats of power (Richardson 2019). Fourth, and related, with the dramatically lowered costs of communication has also come the rise of individuals and public collectives as key actors in political communication. This includes the ways in which newly communicatively empowered audiences have organized social movements, engaged in digital witnessing to hold power to account, and produced routine representations of politics (Chouliaraki 2015).

All of which has meant that public opinion – always a constructed phenomenon – has grown increasingly fragmented and diverse and represented in many different ways. All of these changes have meant a much more challenging strategic communications environment to navigate, but it has also created new opportunities to influence publics.

To start with, there are always *goals* for strategic communication campaigns. And these goals are often shaped by the even larger goals that a political organization has. To provide some examples, goals can entail many things, depending on the political actor (whether it is a non-governmental organization, a social movement, a political party, or anyone or anything else in between) and the context in which strategic communications take shape. For public health communicators, for instance, the public health goal might be to persuade people to get vaccinated during the Covid-19 pandemic, and the strategic communications goal might be to counter misinformation about the safety of vaccines or to develop pro-social messaging so people engage in protective health measures.

Political communicators might also have the goal of influencing smaller audiences that are influential in particular ways. Lobbyists who seek to influence legislation, for instance, might have the strategic communications goals of changing the minds of key legislators around their issues, or cultivating journalists to shape coverage in a way that pressures legislatures to vote a certain way, or collaborating with Instagram influencers or bloggers. Political strategic communicators often share the goal of introducing new ideas into policy or public debates – for example, about the very issues that we should be concerned about and what we should do about them (or not do). Or strategic communicators' goals can be to contest the dominant frames we have for talking about particular issues, such as whether climate change is a matter of public health or long-term economic stability, a humanitarian crisis or a natural one. The outcomes of framing contests often lead to particular definitions of the problem and influence the solutions posed to solve them (Knüpfer & Entman 2018).

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

Strategic communicators often have a goal of creating distinctions between groups, for their own gain. The goal here is to create *difference*. Political elites tell stories: stories about their nations' histories, the types of people who live within them and should live within them, the groups that they will represent, and the relationships between their citizens and the outside world.

As this shows, political elites work to strategically create and invoke political identities in order to pursue their objectives and goals. These “stories of peoplehood” (Smith 2003) are fundamental to politics, which is at its heart about the relationships between groups in societies – who has power (economic, cultural, social, political) and who *should* have power, and which ways of exercising authority and accountability in states are legitimate. The distinctions that political and social elites draw are fundamental to political communication and nations.

Think, for instance, about all the political conflicts over refugees and immigration that have wracked many Western democracies in the past 20 years (Benson 2013; Chavez 2001). Strategic communicators with different partisan and ideological perspectives have contrasting goals around communicating national identity: from a more restrictive, culturally homogeneous state, especially on the political right, to a more inclusive,

expansive, and multicultural vision, especially on the political left. In the routine course of political events, strategic communicators fit their tactics into these larger narratives about what countries are and should be – with the goal of convincing publics of the rightness of their approach. These are, at heart, debates over who is granted citizenship, and who should be. For example, countries such as the United States, throughout its very short history as a multi-ethnic democracy, have been consumed with debates over difference and social and political power. Previously, the US had long secured, as a matter of law and of social norms, unequal power relations based on racial and ethnic categories of citizens. Meanwhile, European powers with their extensive colonial histories not only justified their global conquests through the lens of religious and racial and ethnic difference, they also created deep social difference fissures in the countries they colonized, legacies that remain and structure power today.

The art and practice of making distinctions is not limited to political identities; there are many lines of difference central to the goals of strategic political communicators. They often seek to create symbolic lines of division between themselves and others across any number of dimensions – from interests, ideology, and geography to occupation, policy preferences, and values – to advance their goals and interests and those of the people they claim to represent. Parties create what are matters of public concern, for instance, and, as importantly, define the debates about why these things matter and what to do about them (Aldrich 2011). Parties in parliamentary democracies stake out their issues and ideologies relationally to others, providing voters with choices at the ballot box based on these distinctions.

In other words, there are numerous goals that political communicators work toward and strategies for communicatively achieving them. In turn, political communicators have a number of different informational tools available, especially in the age of platforms. Broadly, we can think about political advertising (we discuss this in much greater detail in the next chapter and only touch on it here), political marketing, public relations, and, for governmental purposes, public diplomacy. These things have changed dramatically with media change, although at their heart they remain deeply indebted to their emergence during the course of the twentieth century in many Western democracies. They are also premised on *campaigns*, by which we mean sustained strategic political communications activity, often taking shape across multiple media and platforms, directed toward the goals and outcomes communicators seek to achieve. And, at their core, they often involve extensive research and data that inform goals, measure progress toward meeting them and the effectiveness of particular tactics, and enable strategic communicators to adjust tactics and goals in the middle of campaigns.

Let's consider a few domains of strategic communications in greater detail.

6.4 Political Marketing

As we have discussed throughout this book, platforms select for engagement. They seek to keep people using platforms in order to monetize their attention and time. This means that platforms incentivize the most engaging content that political organizations and groups promote on social media – which is often the most extreme, emotional, identity-based, or ideologically consistent. Central to understanding political marketing is recognizing that platforms are not neutral means of distributing political content, they *shape* that content in

particular ways by creating incentives for political actors. And these incentives are often aligned with what is best for platforms economically.

These dynamics reveal how platforms are now central to “political marketing.” By political marketing, we mean all attempts by political communicators to promote their policies or ideas, change public opinion, secure political office or political power, or shape public debate, policymaking, or governance more broadly. This is an expansive set of activities! They reflect the fact that, over the course of the twentieth century, strategic communications have grown much more central to governance and electioneering in many democracies, as theories, methods, and tools from commercial marketing have permeated political communication (Henneberg & Ormrod 2013; Lees-Marshment 2012). And, even more, they reflect the fact that there are many different political actors that are routinely engaged in strategic communications, from candidates and parties to advocacy organizations and interest groups. All of these entities engage in strategic communications, and platforms are newly central to just about everything that these groups do.

As with strategic communications more generally, political marketing proceeds from a set of goals that look different depending on the organization that is engaging in the political marketing campaign. These goals could span everything from persuading an electorate to vote for a particular candidate or endorse an issue in a referendum to changing public opinion on an issue about state spending or addressing climate change or public health measures. Political actors can use political marketing in the attempt to build support for a specific bill in a legislature, create accountability over a powerful institution such as the police or a regulatory agency, or change the minds of a small group of powerful legislators or party leaders on an important issue.

These different goals, in turn, give rise to different strategies or tactics. Marketing is a *holistic* approach to positioning some candidate, cause, organization, or party in relation to others in a field in a way that strategically furthers the organization’s goals. This involves: (1) consideration of the organization’s goals; (2) the field of allies and adversaries; (3) analysis of the state of play; and (4) the strengths and weaknesses of the organization symbolically and resource-wise. Political marketing involves a strategic approach to symbolically positioning the organization, in the attempt to convince some set of publics of things that further its progress toward its goals. And, to do so, strategic communicators use a rich set of tools from advertising to branding, from leveraging influencers to speeches by party leaders.

With their goals in mind, political communicators figure out whom they need and want to persuade, how best to reach and appeal to them, and what sorts of communication will likely be the most effective, and at which times. They also think expansively about how to create new publics, identities, or issues that help them advance their goals. Political marketing involves the development of a coherent set of narratives and messages, designed to achieve determined goals, delivered to some set of audiences, through an expansive set of communicative tactics.

Let’s break this down. By “coherent set of narratives and messages,” we mean that there is a *unified theme or set of themes* even if there are different types of communication or messages that convey them. There might not be any one theme to a campaign or cause (there might be a few, after all), but they are not infinite and should not be contradictory. This is important. Campaigns and causes *must* define themselves at some fundamental level, and this means making distinctions – this candidate is for *this* and against *that*; this

cause means that *this* will happen and *that* will be prevented. Candidates and causes can entail a few different things, but in general these things should be coherent and they should be limited – research suggests that messages that have clearly identifiable core elements are the most successful at persuasion and garnering attention (Green 2021).

Of course, political life is more complicated than this. Politicians often avoid taking strong stances on issues, or are strategically ambiguous in their public pronouncements. They do so to give themselves maximum flexibility to respond to evolving situations, or to preserve the widest base of potential support. While this may work for a time, these are always decisions that come with the risk of being first defined by adversaries seeking to create their own distinctions. They might be criticized, if not for the policy positions themselves, then for being weak, noncommittal, indecisive, or pandering.

The choice of a theme or themes behind a candidacy or a cause reflects the *goal*. If the aim is to get a candidate elected, then that is the goal, and the choice of theme is shaped by a clear understanding of what needs to be accomplished (i.e. a majority of votes) and how best to accomplish it. For an election, this means accounting for such things as pre-existing public opinion, partisanship, political culture, and events in the world. For causes, this means an analysis of existing public sentiment, the field of adversaries and their interests and incentives, and targets and opportunities to persuade them.

By “delivered to some set of audiences,” we mean a crucial part of the political marketing process. “Audiences” refers to campaigns and causes having a sense – however vague – of whom they need to reach and how best to reach them. One of the key shifts of the platform era is that we have many, many, many more vehicles for reaching publics than were ever imaginable before. Indeed, we have many new publics themselves – take, for example, communities built around interest and affinity, such as fan communities, or activism on platforms. Political marketers might make their fundamental appeals to journalists, seeking to influence coverage and raise public awareness of a candidate or issue. Or they might leverage journalism as a representation of public opinion as a way to pressure lawmakers to take action on some issue. They might reach out to fan communities directly through influencers, or make appeals for people to adopt the symbols of a candidate or cause as their own identity and spread it within their social networks (Penney 2017). They might stage high-profile actions in certain legislators’ districts, take certain positions in ways that create allies or build coalitions, or work to shape public sentiment on social media as a means to influence the digital staffers of legislators.

All of this reveals the vast array of communication tactics now deployed in political life. From television appearances to staged events that influence journalists’ coverage, from the performative use of Twitter to shape social media sentiment to the branding of causes in ways that convey partisan and social identities, from digital political advertising to TikTok posts – campaigns and causes think holistically about the communicative tools they have in the context of the goals they attempt to achieve. Political marketing, then, is the science and art of taking all of these things into account when determining what communications are most likely going to help political actors achieve their goals. These communicative tactics include messaging and framing, as well as the strategic presentation of campaigns and causes through branding – the process of creating cultural and social meanings around political symbols.

6.5 Public Relations and Public Diplomacy

Broadly, public relations (often falling under the broad label of “communications,” or just “comms,” for political practitioners) concerns the strategic work of creating and maintaining a positive public image for a political organization, campaign, cause, or candidate (Saffer et al. 2013). Often this is done through the creation and maintenance of relationships with key stakeholders – journalists, opinion leaders, influencers, various publics, etc. Communications professionals take into account the broad range of tools that they have at their disposal to achieve their goals. Some of these tools are very well established, such as press briefings, press conferences, and press releases that seek to set journalists’ agendas and the frames they use to discuss politics. Public relations also includes the often extensive behind-the-scenes press work that goes into cultivating relationships with journalists and educating them about public issues or trying to influence patterns of coverage in a strategic way. And communications professionals also work to create public or other appearances for their campaigns or causes, including on television shows, coordinate speeches by key stakeholders, and plan rallies and events that seek to engage with members of the public and gain positive press attention.

In the platform era, there has been an increasing array of ways in which public relations professionals utilize new communicative capacities in the service of creating and fostering a positive public image for their candidates, campaigns, organizations, and causes. For example, press releases are now rarely just for journalists. The contemporary press release gets reworked across many different platforms (to fit with different genres of communication in accord with audience expectations) to appeal to wider publics, including networks of supporters who can engage with and share this content on social media.

Consider a politician who is running for office on a strong environmental platform and who wants to make a case for their candidacy in the aftermath of a natural disaster. Public relations professionals would issue press releases to journalists that detail the candidate’s response to the disaster, attribute potential causes of the disaster, and propose potential solutions so it would not happen again or a district could be better prepared. Often, the details of these press releases would also be versioned on Facebook and Twitter and sent out through email. These campaign professionals would also proactively reach out to journalists to educate them on the issue. The politician might also hold an event and invite members of the press, elected officials, and the public to attend – this would happen through both emails directly to individual stakeholders, and promotions on platforms such as Facebook and Twitter. They might want to ask people to RSVP, in the process capturing emails that can then be added to build a list of media, supporters, etc. At the event, the politician speaks (itself a form of strategic communication) and that potentially shapes how the press understands the issue and coverage of it – in addition to the understandings people themselves have and post about on social media.

The politician’s digital communications team then shares photos of the event on platforms such as Instagram and Facebook, quotes the politician’s words on Twitter, and posts videos on YouTube (there are intricate gender dynamics at play in this – female politicians receive more “Likes” when they are visible in a picture, for instance [Brands et al. 2021]). The campaign hopes that supporters share this text and video within their own social networks, vastly expanding the reach of the communications, especially to those less attentive to politics, in the hopes they might be inadvertently exposed to political information (Scheffauer et al. 2021). Indeed, there is a shift in consumption habits, from a time when

viewers had few options to turn away from mass media, ensuring *inadvertent audiences* (Prior 2007) for content, to the *viewer-choice era* (Lau et al. 2021) we are in today, marked by *lots* of choice in what, when, where, and how much viewers consume media.

Even this understates the possibilities for communication during the platform era and the many, many new possibilities public relations professionals have to cultivate relationships with stakeholders and burnish the public images of their campaigns and causes. While materials such as press releases and press packets have long been established as a genre, think about all the possibilities for platform communication – as well as how rapidly platforms themselves change. Posting on Facebook can include graphics and video or some combination of both, or videos can be streamed live (and archived) on YouTube. Campaigns can release a sequence of content across platforms that potentially reaches millions, including journalists. Tweets can be threaded to provide a more contextual view of events, and Instagram stories can provide more narrative stories. TikTok can reach millions with innovative content that animates political stories (Literat & Kligler-Vilenchik 2023). Meanwhile, the various forms of data provided by these platforms mean that the effectiveness of public relations strategies can be revealed in real time, such as sentiment analysis, shaping future messaging strategy through understandings of what worked and what did not.

Taking public relations to an international level, “public diplomacy” refers to state strategic communications to the populations of foreign countries or international audiences, which have as their intent to influence the attitudes of targets and put political pressure on foreign governments (Manor 2019). Public diplomacy can also be used for “nation-branding” to positively shape a country’s image and reputation for audiences in other countries, including for economic reasons (Miño & Austin 2022). To pursue these goals, many countries broadcast television or radio shows in other nations, including in different languages – Russia Today is an infamous case in point, but also Germany’s Deutsche Welle, Al Jazeera, the US’s Voice of America, and the BBC’s World Service, which reactivated two short-wave channels in Ukraine after the Russian invasion in 2022.

In the digital age, bots and state-affiliated troll farms (Howard et al. 2018) – most famously the Russian Internet Research Agency’s attempt to influence elections or referendums around the world – have provided prominent cases of state-level attempts to influence public and electoral dynamics in other countries. These are simply the most extreme examples of what are often routine forms of engagement by many countries around the world that see strategic advantage in wielding informational dynamics to their advantage. The quarterly transparency reports by major platforms such as Facebook, Google, and Twitter, for instance, provide substantial evidence of state-backed networks attempting the malicious manipulation of foreign publics – and these reports are obviously limited to the cases detected and sanctioned by the platforms.

There are also more routine ways in which digitalization has influenced and transformed public diplomacy. Digitalization refers to “the way many domains of social life are restructured around digital communication and media infrastructures” (Brennen & Kreiss 2016). Diplomats, foreign ministers, and embassies have turned to social media for their external communications, and to some extent even for their internal communication. Ilan Manor (2019) gives the example of UN ambassadors using WhatsApp groups to coordinate their votes and resolutions, or nations using images for “selfie diplomacy.” A key impact has also been that digital platforms opened the opportunity to speak to international

audiences, and national ones, for a wider range of actors including NGOs, small activist groups, and even terrorist groups.

Thinking of extreme examples, we should take a look at strategic communication and public diplomacy in times of war, as both (or sometimes several) sides seek to frame war to their advantage. You may be familiar with the proverb that the first casualty is the truth when war breaks out. This reflects the level of strategic communication by parties in a conflict, and the fight over whose interpretations of events will prevail. Is the war legitimate? Is it a war, or just a special military operation? Who is to blame? Is it an act of aggression or self-defense? How many lies can be counted? Who is the victor; who lost the war?

In a digital environment, however, it is not only governments, professional media, and military actors who participate in the game of presenting, interpreting, and telling their version of events, but also civil society groups, individual stakeholders, networks of activists and partisans, and even celebrities.

SPOTLIGHTED CASE

Arnold Schwarzenegger posted a video addressed to the Russian people on Twitter on March 17, 2022, during the war in Ukraine. In the video, the Hollywood star and former governor of California first speaks about his connections with and his love for Russia, about his fond childhood memories of meeting a Russian weightlifter, and his own father's trauma as a soldier in World War II. He then tells his (presumed Russian) audience that they have been misinformed about the war and violence going on in Ukraine. He appeals to Russian soldiers to not get physically and mentally broken like his father by becoming guilty of war crimes, indirectly asking them to desert. It is a brilliant example of persuasive communication, employing psychological techniques to gain the trust of the audience and break their resilience against a message they might not want to hear. Interestingly, he also addresses Vladimir Putin directly – after all, @Schwarzenegger was one of only 22 accounts followed by the official Russian president's Twitter account, @KremlinRussia_E.

6.6 Crisis Communication

Crisis communication “can be defined as the strategic use of words and actions to manage information and meaning during the crisis process” (Coombs 2018). The idea of a “crisis process” refers to the fact that a crisis has several phases, each of which may require different approaches to strategic communication. Take, for instance, the crisis of a global pandemic, such as Covid-19. At its very core, it was a health crisis, forcing governments around the globe to take actions that affected the freedom of their citizens, such as imposing lockdowns or vaccine mandates. As the pandemic evolved and means of mitigation were developed, like tests and vaccines, the crisis communication of governments also changed. Because science delivered new knowledge frequently, the messages and measures needed to be adapted, and even sometimes reversed. This is very challenging for strategic communicators, because in such cases communications cannot be

consistent, they need to reflect the current stage of an ever evolving situation and must take into account new insights into the crisis.

Among examples are the mask mandates that were differentially embraced in countries around the world. While most scientists believed at the beginning of the pandemic that masks would not help much, they became a key measure of limiting health risk in many countries later on, and governments the world over had to explain changes in policy to their citizens. In short: A crisis makes one of the most central requirements of strategic communication difficult: a consistent message. Crises “are fluid, and communicative demands can change as the crisis morphs” (Coombs 2018).

Even more, a massive crisis such as a pandemic does not remain a health crisis, but affects other parts of society as well. The Covid-19 pandemic soon led to economic crises in many countries, with steep increases in unemployment and precarious work; public education crises with home-schooling and closed schools; many social crises, such as increases in domestic violence, isolation, and depression among the most vulnerable groups in society; and certainly political crises, as governments struggled to find the right balance between public health and individual freedom. Each of these crises required their own communication strategies, adding to the complexity of governmental and stakeholder response.

Another aspect of crisis communication relates to organizational crises, when companies, NGOs, or government agencies face scandals and losses in reputation and trust. Crisis communicators have a number of different communicative strategies at their disposal to respond to reputational threats based on attributions of responsibility for crises. Depending on whether the organization is cast as the victim or the perpetrator, the effective response frames are well established, ranging from attacking accusers, finding scapegoats, and making excuses or justifications to accepting responsibility and offering changes and accountability (Coombs 2018). In the middle of an unfolding crisis, communicators have to be responsive to in-the-moment flows of information and the unfolding of public opinion on platforms such as Twitter, which they desperately try to stay on top of and even direct to shape public understanding and response to the crisis. This includes issuing tweets and statements with crisis responses while monitoring real-time public and stakeholder opinion and attempting to shape it. Depending on the crisis and culpability, organizations might use social media to self-disclose information, apologize, and seek to remedy the situation.

In other words, social media create new contexts for political crisis communications. In a meta-analysis of over 100 scholarly articles about effective social media crisis communication, Mats Eriksson (2018: 526) found five key tactics: “(1) exploiting social media’s potential to create dialogue and to choose the right message, source and timing; (2) performing pre crisis work and developing an understanding of the social media logic; (3) using social media monitoring; (4) continuing to prioritize traditional media in crisis situations; and finally, (5) just using social media in strategic crisis communication.” The latter can actually be a game-changer due to the speed of communication and the possibilities it opens to get a message out or respond to events, for instance during natural disasters, such as the devastating Italian earthquakes in 2016 (Splendiani & Capriello 2022).

SPOTLIGHTED CASE

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky took to Twitter to rally the support of Western democracies in the face of Russia's invasion of his country in February 2022. His message was simple: We are here, the government is staying, and working, and democracies have a responsibility to defend one of their own. He shared video messages on platforms and with new media, and appealed to foreign parliaments and governments via Twitter, successfully seeking support and to gain agency and symbolic power over the framing of the events.

6.7 Digital Lobbying

“Lobbying” refers to attempts to influence policymaking without being directly involved in the process (e.g. Hoffman 2015). As such, it takes place on an intermediary level – between stakeholder groups and those in political power. There are many forms of lobbying, but, as a professional occupation, lobbyists put forward the interests of the advocacy groups or industries who pay them to do so. They make their political networks and persuasive talents available to these groups, and represent their clients’ interests or grievances to politicians in power.

Historically, the term “lobbying” reflects the intermingling of powerful people and members of parliament in hotel lobbies, antehalls of parliament buildings, or smoke-filled backrooms, where they cut deals and bargains away from the public eye. Indeed, lobbying is often considered a sinister, bad practice undermining the democratic process and policymaking for the common good. However, democracies thrive on pluralism – the coexistence of a plurality of particular interests that compete and conflict with one another in a marketplace of ideas. Thus, it is a fundamental right in democratic societies to petition decision-makers on behalf of the interest of one’s group or community. Lobbyists also provide information, expertise, and connections around the issues and groups they represent, as a resource to politicians. In most democracies, lobbying is legally regulated, and usually lobbyist organizations or individual lobbyists register as such in parliaments. In fact, lobbying is quite pervasive in democracies. In the US, for example, the money spent on lobbying Congress and federal agencies has roughly doubled since 1998 (\$3.7 billion US in 2022), while the number of active lobbyists remained about the same (OpenSecrets 2022).

There are lobbyists on both (or many) sides of issues. Think of lobbyists who work for pro-life versus pro-choice groups, or those who represent public health organizations versus the producers of tobacco products and their employees. Traditionally, lobbying is a form of interpersonal communication, but it can be mediatized as well. Lobbying rarely seeks directly to mobilize large crowds, such as at rallies, demonstrations, or protests (although these things can be used in tandem with lobbying efforts to pressure targets). However, lobbyists can use platforms to get into close contact with their target audiences – politicians.

For example, with the advent of platforms, the costs of lobbying – defined expansively here in terms of direct appeals to policymakers – decreased, making it easier for small

interest groups or communities to contact politicians directly. After all, not everyone can afford to pay a professional lobbyist, but platforms have made it much easier to approach politicians directly, not via a paid lobbyist, to get their attention.

One case to illustrate this is the “We are more than numbers” campaign of Norwegian mothers of chronically ill children in 2017, which Tine Ustad Figenschou and Kjersti Thorbjørnsrud (2020) analyzed in an interview-based study. Protesting against a proposal to reduce the welfare income of these families, a network of mothers posted “heart-wrenching public letters” on the Facebook pages of the country’s prime minister and health and social ministers. A small ad hoc network of mothers engaged in personalized, emotional, and authentic storytelling, taking selfies at the bedsides of their children and providing first-hand accounts of their grievances. They targeted politicians directly by posting on their Facebook pages and tagging them in posts, but also strategically aimed for user engagement and, consequently, media coverage: “It sounds harsh, but sick children ‘sell.’ It is perhaps our strongest card because we can share our stories and others share theirs. This way we have managed to create massive engagement, likes and shares ... It evokes strong emotions because it is unfair and affects young, helpless, innocent children – who cannot stand up for themselves” (Ustad Figenschou & Thorbjørnsrud 2020: 174). The authors conclude that, while it was powerful, it also confronts the mothers with moral dilemmas such as invading the privacy of their children, and challenges them to negotiate their own roles as parents and as lay activists.

In their analysis of the logics of digital advocacy, Håkan Johansson and Gabriella Scaramuzzino (2019) argue that social media platforms opened up a new way of lobbying – not only seeking political influence, but building up political presence. Traditionally, lobbying meant negotiating directly with politicians. Now, digital media enable advocacy groups to establish themselves as political actors by demonstrating and amplifying their connections with politicians: “While a logic of influence presupposes a key message, a logic of presence is oriented towards promoting ‘who you are’ rather than ‘what you stand for’” (2019: 1542).

6.8 Summary

In this chapter, we have seen how capacious strategic political communication can be in the time of platforms. In an era when press releases to journalists have become real-time tweets, strategic political communicators must be comparatively “always on,” attuned to the dynamics of public opinion. They must be able and willing to respond to developments and issues on sites such as Twitter, and use many different strategies, tactics, media, and platforms to get their message out and shape journalistic coverage for strategic ends. And they must have the flexibility to realize their goals during complex unfolding events and in response to many different types of contestation. They do so with many new tools at their disposal, including paid platform communications to reach new audiences, and strategic platform influence campaigns to pressure powerful targets.

Discussion Questions

- What are the differences between strategic communication and political communication?
- Strategic communication is essentially about persuasion. How is persuasion on platforms different from persuasion through broadcasting?

Suggestions for Further Reading

Figenschou, T. U. & Fredheim, N. A. (2020) “Interest groups on social media: four forms of networked advocacy,” *Journal of Public Affairs* 20(2): 1–8.

Holtzhausen, D. & Zerfass, A. (eds.) (2015) *The Routledge Handbook of Strategic Communication*. New York: Routledge.

Jamieson, K. H. (2017) *The Oxford Handbook of Political Communication*. Oxford University Press.

Lilleker, D., Coman, I. A., Gregor, M., & Novelli, E. (2021) *Political Communication and COVID-19: Governance and Rhetoric in Times of Crisis*. London: Routledge.

Strömbäck, J. & Kioussis, S. (eds.) (2019) *Political Public Relations: Concepts, Principles, and Applications*. New York: Routledge.